

Links between Finland and the United Kingdom in science and higher education

For a small country like Finland, international cooperation is of paramount importance. As one of Europe's leading countries in science, the United Kingdom is naturally an important partner for Finland. According to statistics from the Nature Index,¹ the United Kingdom ranks fourth in the world in scientific research and is the fourth most important partner for Finnish researchers behind the United States, China and Germany. In world university rankings, UK universities are usually among the best (THE:² 1. Oxford, 5. Cambridge, 8. Imperial College; QS:³ 2. Imperial College, 4. Oxford, 6. Cambridge, 8. UCL; ARWU:⁴ 4. Cambridge, 6. Oxford).

Brexit created many new obstacles to cooperation between Finland and the United Kingdom, and removing them is important for Finnish science. A step in the right direction was taken at the beginning of 2024 when the United Kingdom joined the European Union's Horizon Europe programme. However, there are still several important unresolved issues:

1. Mobility of researchers:

Researcher mobility is important both for maintaining existing research collaboration and for creating new collaborations. Short-term research visits by Finns to the UK are often based on Finnish funding, while Finnish researchers working in the UK for a longer period of time are usually employed by a British employer. The visa and work permit requirements that came into force with Brexit have significantly increased bureaucracy and costs in both cases.

The Global Talent visa, which is valid for five years and is renewable, is available to leading researchers and their family members. The visa costs £766 per person, in addition to which an immigration health surcharge of £776–1,035 per person per year must be paid. For a family of four, for example, the additional cost over five years is more than £20,000. Since the salaries of researchers are often not very high, this is a significant obstacle to mobility. In addition, a person working on a visa is not entitled to UK state benefits such as Child Benefit.

The number of Finnish academic staff at UK universities decreased by 9% from the academic year 2018-19 to the academic year 2023-24, but has now started to rise.⁵ The statistics do not show the number of new Finnish researchers arriving in the UK, but some indication can be obtained from the fact that the number of EU citizens in fixed-term research positions decreased by 32% from the academic year 2017-18 to the academic year 2024-25.⁶

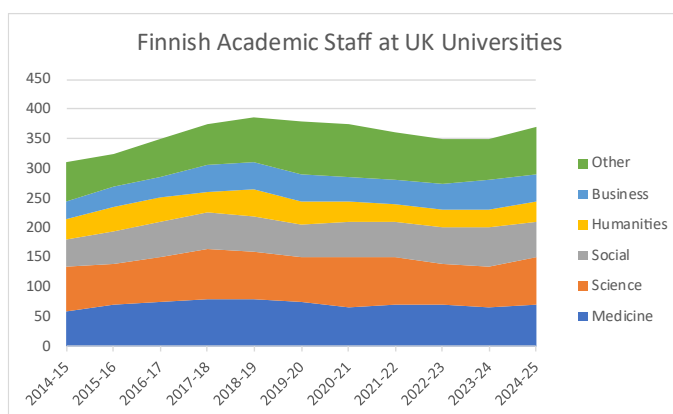


Figure 1: Finnish academic staff at UK universities

¹ <https://www.natureindex.com/country-outputs/Finland>

² <https://www.timeshighereducation.com/world-university-rankings/latest/world-ranking>

³ <https://www.topuniversities.com/world-university-rankings>

⁴ <https://www.shanghairanking.com/rankings/arwu/2024>

⁵ <https://www.hesa.ac.uk/data-and-analysis/staff/table-12>

⁶ <https://www.hesa.ac.uk/data-and-analysis/staff/table-4>

2. Postgraduate research:

Postgraduate study abroad is one of the most concrete ways for Finnish researchers to create international links which can lead to long-term collaboration. The doctoral research and the contacts established during it often lay the foundation for a researcher's entire subsequent career. Funding for doctoral research can come from many different sources, but in most fields, the main funder in the UK is UK Research and Innovation (UKRI). Finnish students

are eligible for UKRI PhD funding, which includes a stipend for living expenses but covers tuition fees only at the UK student rate, currently £5,238 per year. Since Brexit, Finnish postgraduate students have to pay the overseas tuition fee, which is typically much higher, for example £32,700 per year for PhD studies in Physics at Imperial College London. The difference must either be covered from other funding sources or paid by the student. As a result, the number of Finnish doctoral students in the UK has dropped by 58% from the academic year 2016-17 to the academic year 2024-25.⁷

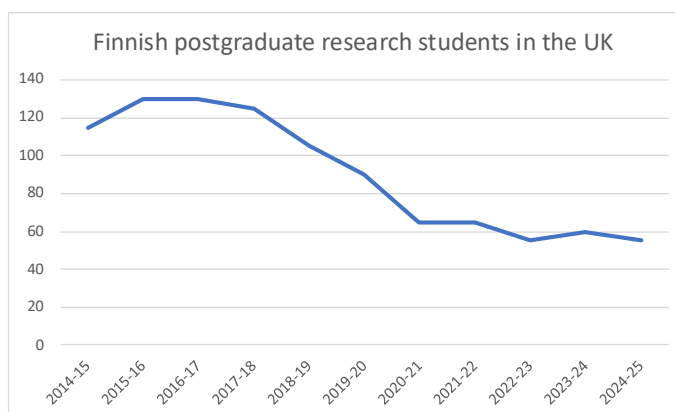


Figure 2: The number of Finnish doctoral students at UK universities.

3. Undergraduate study:

Undergraduate study also plays an important role in creating international connections. Before Brexit, the United Kingdom was the most popular destination for Finnish undergraduate degree students abroad. Now, high tuition fees have made undergraduate study in the UK all but impossible for most Finns. For example, the tuition fee for an undergraduate degree in Physics at Imperial College is £45,500 per year. The number of applicants from Finland to UK universities has decreased significantly. In 2015,⁸

there were 1,010 applicants living in Finland, according to UCAS statistics, and by 2025, the figure had fallen by 90% to just 100. According to Kela's statistics, 2,198 recipients of Finnish student financial aid studied in the UK in the academic year 2018-19, and only 518 in the academic year 2023-24, corresponding to a drop of 76%.⁹

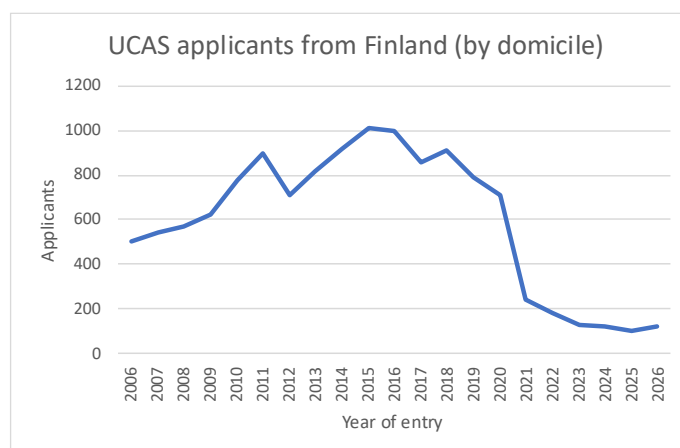


Figure 3: Number of applications from Finland to undergraduate programmes at UK universities

⁷ <https://www.hesa.ac.uk/data-and-analysis/students/where-from>

⁸ <https://www.ucas.com/>

⁹ <https://tietotarjotin.fi/tilasto/2872983/tilasto-opintotuesta>

It is expected that the decline of researcher and student mobility between Finland and the United Kingdom will have serious consequences for scientific cooperation between the countries in the coming years and decades. According to statistics, Brexit has had a similar impact on mobility between the United Kingdom and other EU countries as well, but the impact has been particularly severe for Finland. In light of the statistics, it also seems that although some student mobility has shifted to EU countries, especially the Netherlands, this has only partially compensated for the decline in mobility to the UK.

For this reason, it is important to actively seek to remove obstacles to mobility between Finland and the United Kingdom. This can be done in part, for example, by creating exchange programmes between universities or funding models that facilitate mobility, such as scholarships for studying abroad. However, a comprehensive solution to the problem requires a mobility agreement between the European Union and the United Kingdom covering both tuition fees and visas, including the immigration health surcharge. The ongoing negotiations on this issue are therefore very important.

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